Making a Map: Finding My Way Back Juvenile Justice Project

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Background

- Juvenile incarceration disproportionately affects youth with disabilities, especially youth with emotional behavior disabilities (EBD)
- Youth with EBD comprise over 47.4 percent of students with disabilities in secure care, while within public schools they account for approximately .08% of students with disabilities (NWCD, 2016).
- 20% of youth with EBD were arrested while in secondary school (NLTS-2)
- Juvenile offenders face great challenges (Griller Clark & Unruh, 2010)

Research Questions

1. What were the experiences of Check and Connect (C&C) mentors working with youth offenders in the juvenile justice (JJ) system?
2. What are the challenges associated with implementing a mentoring program for youth with disabilities in JJ system?

Participants

Mentors

- Five mentors who served 63 juvenile offenders
- Four male and 1 female

Students

- 63 juvenile offenders (60 male)
- EBD (40), LD (15), OHD (8)
- Average age=15 , mode=16 years

Method

Overview. This study draws on interview data from four C&C mentors who worked with juvenile offenders who participated in a four-year demonstration project-the MAP project.

Goal of the MAP Project. To support juvenile offenders with disabilities transitioning from a correctional facility into schools and communities, using C&C model, an evidence-based student engagement model.

Intervention. Check and Connect, a student engagement model, was the primary intervention used in this study. Mentors monitored students' grades, weekly behavior, and provided individualized intervention accordingly.

Procedure

- Interviews (1 to 1.5 hours long)
- Two focus groups (1 hour for each, 8 to 10 people per group)
- Audio-recorded both interviews and focus groups and later transcribed
- *Nvivo* was used for coding

Quotes from mentors

"One of the best moments I had was going to one of my kids' high school graduation. He was here at Totem Town, he transitioned to the community, finished school, got his credits done, and was able to walk across the stage with his diploma. That had nothing to do with me; it had everything to do with him. But that was awesome, to sit and say, 'I know him, I know him and I know the work that he's done in the four years that it took to get him here.'

"Once I had students on my caseload, it was checking in with them; checking in with their team of people, including their case managers, their probation officers, their parents; and preparing them for that transition back into the community...getting them ready for what things will look like."

Results (Identified Themes)

Figure 1 main themes from analysis of the mentors' interview

Research Question	Key Themes
Description of the intervention	• Providing individualized support for students; • Connecting with parents & collaborating with staff and agencies involved with the student
Challenges to implementation	• Low student engagement & motivation • Students' lives are chaotic and highly transient • Families lack resources • Caseload expectation is too high • Schools and correctional facilities lack resources and capacity to adequately support JJ-involved students with disabilities • Difficult to engage families • Schools struggle to hold JJ-involved students with disabilities accountable
Perceived outcomes	Helps reduce parent stress; mentors fill a gap in existing services; mentors increase student motivation & academic performance; students gain confidence
Perceived value of MAP program	Mentors are role models, caring adults, and advocates; mentors hold students accountable and help correct negative behavior

Discussing and Conclusion

- Challenges reported by mentors are consistent with those reported in previous studies (Griller Clark et al., 2010)
- Family engagement continues to be a challenging task
- Check and Connect mentors fill a gap in existing services provided by schools serving juvenile offenders

References

National Collaborative on Workforce and Disability (2017). Youth involved in the juvenile correction system. retrieved from http://www.ncwd-youth.info/youth-in-juvenile-corrections.

Griller Clark, H., & Unruh, D. (2010). Transition practices for adjudicated youth with E/BDs and related disabilities. Behavioral Disorders, 36, 43-51.

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